

Geography

U.S.





About the Course

Students focus on US geography using maps, illustrations, and historical narratives about travelers during the 19th century.



Placement & Combining Tips

This course is different for each of the historical time periods, but always retains a topical focus on US geography.



Scheduling

GRADE	SCHEDULE INFO.	BOOKS
8	Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) 2 times/week 30 min	Student World Atlas 6th Ed. United States Atlas 7th Ed. This Strange Wilderness: The Life and Art of John James Audubon Our States Have Crazy Shapes Westward with Fremont: The Story of Solomon Carvalho

Sample Weekly View

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5
Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)				
Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)		Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)		



Planning & Prep

Permission to print for non-commercial use. See Alveary group use policy to use lessons in a group context.

LINKS: Click text or scan the QR code in the top corner of the lesson plan pages to view online resources associated with the lessons.

Responsibility for previewing all links rests with the teacher. All links were checked at the time of publication; however, websites change frequently and may contain objectionable content. Please report broken links by contacting us through our website.



Books & Resources

For book rationales and purchase options, click the Book List link or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Book List Details](#)

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)



Student World Atlas 6th Ed.



United States Atlas 7th Ed.



This Strange Wilderness: The Life and Art of John James Audubon



Our States Have Crazy Shapes



Westward with Fremont: The Story of Solomon Carvalho



Supplies

For supply list details and basic supplies helpful to have on hand, click the links or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Basic Supplies](#)

(No Subject Supplies Assigned)



Quick Links

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

∞ [Student Lessons \(No Answers\)](#)

∞ [Foundations \(See Section 16: Geography\)](#)

Click THIS text
or scan the QR
code for links.



Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

How To Teach

	Overview The steps below are generally true for most geography lessons. Sometimes several lessons might build together or focus on a particular area (like Map Work).
	Introduce Through questions, observations, an activity, or recalling the last lesson, introduce the topic for the day.
	Map Questions Answer questions on the map or on making your own maps.
	Read Read the day's passage out loud or have the student read independently.
	Narrate Have students retell the passage either orally or in writing. They may want to use maps or pictures to tell back.
	Map Work The lesson may contain more map work as students make their own maps or add to ongoing maps.

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

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Term 1

WEEK 1 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 1

Solomon Carvalho: Solomon Joins Fremont

Materials: Westward with Fremont, notebook, United States Atlas, blank map

→ PREP

Your geography notebook will be used on both days of the week. You may be asked to make an entry or to tape your printed maps for Map Work. Ensure that each entry is labeled with the date or lesson number. Your notebook should have a minimum of 70 pages. It is suggested to label the first page in your notebook “Solomon Carvalho’s Journey” and set aside the next 5 pages. Place a marker or paper clip, label the page “John Audubon’s Wilderness Travels,” and save 5 pages. Place another marker. This section will be used on the second day for notebooking work; label the title page for that section “The United States of America.”

→ INTRODUCTION

Westward with Fremont: The Story of Solomon Carvalho tells the true story of a dangerous expedition led by explorer John C. Fremont and documented by photographer Solomon Nunes Carvalho. Carvalho was not a mountain man or soldier; he was an ordinary person and an artist. Armed with early photographic equipment, he traveled across the Great Plains, through the towering Rocky Mountains, and into the arid lands of the Great Basin, eventually reaching California. You will particularly study the river systems and mountain ranges traveled by the expedition. During the expedition, not all states were established; there were many regions they traveled through that were still considered territories.

→ LOCATE

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.27

1. In your United States Atlas, locate Washington, D.C., New York City (New York), and Baltimore (Maryland). These are major cities in the Eastern region of the country. Notice that Washington, D.C., is labeled as the District of Columbia on the map.
2. What states border the city of Washington, D.C.? [A: Maryland and Virginia] The city is not part of either state. It is the capital city of the country.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.1-2 p.1-11 “I give you” - “their Jewish neighbors.”

→ MAP WORK

Map Resource: geography notebook, blank map of U.S.

Map Link: Country Outline Map

Map Link: Blank Map of U.S.

In your notebook, print and tape the blank map of the United States on the page after your “Solomon Carvalho’s Journey” page. Notice that one map includes all the state outlines while the other does not. If you feel you need the state borders to guide you, then use the Blank Map of U.S. If you feel you want to place your own borders or territory sections, then choose the Country Outline Map.

You will use this map to record Solomon’s journey throughout future lessons. Title the map “Solomon’s Journey West.” Locate Baltimore, Maryland. Draw a house to signify Solomon’s hometown. Now, locate the 38th parallel and draw a faint dotted line along the map. This will be the route the group will try to follow.

• DEFINITIONS

expedition: a journey taken for a specific purpose, often exploration

frontier: the edge of settled land

daguerreotype: an early type of photograph made on a metal plate

survey: to measure and map land

38th Parallel in the United States:

passes through California (near San Francisco/Mono Lake), Nevada (Henderson/Hoover Dam), Arizona (Grand Canyon), Oklahoma (Tulsa), Missouri, Kentucky, and Virginia

• EXTRA HELPING

This short video talks about the history of the daguerreotype and who it is named after.

Video Link: History of Daguerreotype

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

WEEK 1 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 2

Northeastern U.S.

Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook

PREP: Print 8 copies of the linked United States blank map, to be used over the next several weeks. One of these is to be placed in your student's geography notebook (leave an opposite page blank for the state capitals). States will be added from week to week, and the map will be used to study each week. The additional maps are used at the beginning of each week's lesson to see what the student remembers.

∞ Map Link: Blank Map of U.S.

→ INTRO

The second lesson each week in Geography will be spent on Map Questions and Map Work/Projects. There is a Read, Narrate, & Discuss portion from Our States Have Crazy Shapes that will cover two states per lesson in order of their acquired statehood. Please work for the time scheduled. There will be days when your state notebook entries might not be possible. Save those entries for another day or when you can return to them. It is recommended that you find a game about the states or follow along with the "Extra Helpings" of video suggestions to enlighten your assigned reading about each state.

→ MAP WORK

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.14-15, 27

1. Our stories this year are about the journey of Solomon Carvalho and the adventures of John James Audubon. They begin in the eastern part of the United States, but we will take you through to the West Coast of the United States. Day two will focus on each region of the United States. We will begin in the northeastern part and will work our way to fill the entire map of the United States.
2. Read p.14-15 about our "giant patchwork quilt."
3. Now turn to p.27 and locate Maine, New Hampshire, and Vermont. Add them to your blank map that you will place in your geography notebook.
4. What country borders these states to the North? [A: Canada] What ocean borders the states to the east? [A: Atlantic Ocean] Add Canada and the Atlantic Ocean to your map.
5. Tape this map into your notebook. On the blank opposite page, start a state capital list. Add the state and capitals for Maine, New Hampshire, and Vermont to your list.
6. Spend some time studying the states, their capitals, and the region. Next week, you will fill these in from memory.

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Delaware and Pennsylvania (pick one state)

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.1-2 p.33-39

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.33, 47

1. Draw an outline of Delaware and Pennsylvania on separate pages in your notebook in "The United States of America" section. Moving forward, any states that you draw will be in this section. Be sure to label each page with the state name at the top. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?
2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.
3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries. See example below.

∞ Image Link: Example of State Map

• EXTRA HELPING

View the video tour of Acadia National Park.

∞ Video Link: Acadia National Park

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

WEEK 2 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 3

Solomon Carvalho: Solomon Joins Fremont

Materials: Westward with Fremont, geography notebook, United States Atlas, Rivers Map

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.101

1. Locate St. Louis on p.101.
2. Locate the Missouri River. The river starts in the Rocky Mountains in southwestern Montana and ends just north of St. Louis, Missouri. It runs about 2,341 miles and is the longest river in the U.S.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.12-21 "Baltimore, with its" - "turned everything silver."

→ MAP WORK

Map Resource: geography notebook

In the Solomon Carvalho section on the map of the U.S., use a color pen or pencil to draw the Missouri River on the blank map. You will be drawing several rivers during the study of this expedition. For reference, you may use the link to the Rivers Map to help you draw your own rivers on the blank map in your notebook. As you continue reading, you will notice how closely the expedition followed the rivers during their journey.

∞ Map Link: Rivers Map

• DEFINITIONS

provisions: supplies needed for a journey

terrain: physical features of the land

command: authority to lead

Sefardi Jew: Jewish people that trace their historic origins to the Iberian Peninsula (Spain and Portugal)

WEEK 2 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 4

Northeastern U.S.

Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook

PREP: Make sure you have a blank map of the U.S.

∞ Map Link: Blank Map of U.S.

→ MAP WORK

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.27, blank map of the U.S.

1. Using a fresh blank map, fill out the states, capitals, and other labels you remember from last week.
2. Use the map in your notebook to check your work. Add anything you missed.
3. On p.27, locate the following states: New York, Connecticut, Rhode Island, and Massachusetts. Add these to the map in your notebook.
4. Add the states and capitals for New York, Connecticut, Rhode Island, and Massachusetts on the state capitals page.
5. Spend some time studying the states, their capitals, and the region. Next week, you will fill these in from memory.

→ MAP QUESTIONS

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.10-11

1. Looking at the northeastern region of the United States, what is the predominant climate zone? [A: Cold Wet in the far north and the lower states in the region are Temperate Wet]
2. Based on the Warming Up map on p.11, is the region experiencing a warming trend? [A: Yes, the Northeast is well above its usual temperatures for 2021.]

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

New Jersey and Georgia (pick one state)

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.3-4 p.41-48

📄 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.43, 65

1. Draw an outline of New Jersey and Georgia, observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?
2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.
3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries. See example below.

∞ Image Link: Example of State Map

WEEK 3 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 5

Solomon Carvalho: Westward from St. Louis

📄 Materials: Westward with Fremont, geography notebook, United States Atlas

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

📄 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.89, 101

1. Locate Kansas City (Westport), MO, p.101. Westport was a trading post town during the time of the expedition. It was later annexed to be part of modern-day Kansas City, MO, in 1897.
2. Locate the Illinois River p.89. The river is part of the Illinois Waterway, connecting the Great Lakes to the Mississippi River, serving as a major commercial navigation route. It is about 273 miles long.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Westward with Fremont Ch.4-5 p.22-35 “Father sniffed at” - “he said.”

→ MAP WORK

📄 Map Resource: geography notebook

On your map in the Solomon Carvalho section, use a color pen or pencil to draw the Illinois River. Now find Westport, MI, draw a dot, and label “Start of Expedition.”

• IMPORTANT DATES

Westward migration peak 1840s–1850s

• DEFINITIONS

territory: an organized division of a country that is not yet admitted to the full rights of a state

river basin: land drained by a river

WEEK 3 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 6

Northeastern U.S.

📄 Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook

PREP: Make sure you have a blank map of the U.S.

∞ Map Link: Blank Map of U.S.

→ MAP WORK

📄 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.27

1. Using a fresh blank map, fill in the states, capitals, and other labels you remember from last week.
2. Use the map in your notebook to check your work. Add anything you missed.
3. On p.27, locate the following states: Pennsylvania, New Jersey, Delaware, and Maryland. Add these to your map in your notebook.
4. Add the states and capitals for Pennsylvania, New Jersey, Delaware, and Maryland on the state capitals page.
5. Spend some time studying the states, their capitals, and the region. Next week, you will fill these in from memory.

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

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Term 1

Connecticut and Massachusetts (pick one state)

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.5-6 p.49-56

📄 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.31, 39

1. Draw an outline of Connecticut and Massachusetts on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?

2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.

3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

WEEK 4 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 7

Solomon Carvalho: Westward from St. Louis

📄 Materials: Westward with Fremont, geography notebook, United States Atlas

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

📄 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.95

1. Locate the Republican River on p.95. It is in the central Great Plains of North America, starting in eastern Colorado and flowing east through Nebraska and Kansas. It runs about 453 miles.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Westward with Fremont Ch.6 p.36-45 "The Delaware Indians" - "remember at all."

→ MAP WORK

📄 Map Resource: geography notebook

On a new page in your notebook, draw a bison. You may use the link to learn how to draw it. If you want to learn more about them, watch the video. On your map, draw a very small bison in the areas just south of the Republican River.

∞ Video Link: Draw a Bison

∞ Video Link: Bison of North America

• DEFINITIONS

prairie: wide grassland

climate: long-term weather pattern

bison: large Plains animal

WEEK 4 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 8

Northeastern U.S. Regional Features

📄 Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook

PREP: You will need two different maps for today—the U.S. and the Northeastern Region

∞ Map Link: Blank map of the Northeastern Region

∞ Map Link: Blank Map of the U.S.

→ MAP WORK

📄 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.26-27

1. Using a fresh blank U.S. map, fill out the states, capitals, and the geographical features you remember.

2. Use the map in your notebook to check your work. Add anything you missed.

3. On your printed blank map of the northeastern region, add geographical physical features.

4. On the topographical/physical map (p.26), is there anything you notice about the geographical physical features of the northeastern region? What geographical features stand out?

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

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Term 1

5. Locate Lake Erie. What geographical features are near Lake Erie? Find the Erie Canal, Niagara Falls, and Lake Ontario. Label the new map.
6. Locate Massachusetts Bay. Find the following near the bay: Gulf of Maine, Cape Ann, Cape Cod, and Martha's Vineyard. Label the new map.
7. Locate the Hudson River and Appalachian Mountains. Label the new map.
8. Tape this map into your notebook and label it Northeast Region. You will add 4 other regional maps to your notebook throughout the year, so leave the next 4 pages empty for upcoming maps.
9. Spend some time studying the features you have added.

→ MAP QUESTIONS

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.26-27

1. Find the Appalachian Mountains. What other mountain ranges are close to the Appalachians in the northeastern region? [A: White Mountains, Allegheny Mountains, Catskill Mountains, Adirondack Mountains] The Appalachians stretch from the Island of Newfoundland in Canada to central Alabama in the United States. The range is about 2,050 mi (3,300 km).
2. What is the highest mountain in the northeastern region? [A: Mt. Washington at 6,288.2 ft/1,917 m in New Hampshire]

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Maryland and South Carolina (pick one state)

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.7-8 p.57-63

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.37, 75

1. Draw an outline of Maryland and South Carolina on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?
2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.
3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

WEEK 5 □ 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 9

Solomon Carvalho: Westward from St. Louis

□ Materials: Westward with Fremont, geography notebook, United States Atlas

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.95, 128

1. Locate the Arkansas River on p.95. The river runs about 1,469 miles, starting in Colorado, running through Kansas, Oklahoma, Arkansas, and eventually joining the Mississippi River.
2. Locate the Rocky Mountains on p.128. The range expands about 3,000 miles, with some of the highest peaks stretching over 14,000 feet. Seventy-eight of those peaks are found in Colorado.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Westward with Fremont Ch.7 p.46-57 "The Cheyenne and" - "the Ute Indians."

→ MAP WORK

Use this time to catch up and/or add to notebook entries for Day 1 or Day 2.

Preview content on p.47 where scalps of enemies are described.

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

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Term 1

WEEK 5 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 10

Local

Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank maps, geography notebook, colored pencils, pastels, or watercolors

PREP: You will need a blank map for today.

∞ Map Link: Blank Map of the Northeastern Region

→ MAP WORK (NORTHEASTERN REGIONAL)

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.26-27

1. Using a blank map, fill in the geographical features and states you remember.
2. Check your work and anything you missed.

→ MAP QUESTIONS (LOCAL)

Map Resource: State map (Google Maps)

1. Locate your city or closest municipality. What part of the state is it located in?
2. Locate your county. What are the bordering counties?
3. How far away is your city from the northern border of your state? Southern border? Eastern border? Western border?
4. Locate the capital of your state. Which direction would you travel to get there from your home?
5. Can you find a line of latitude and longitude that runs through your state?
6. Find the bodies of water and watercourses.

→ MAP WORK

You are going to draw an aerial view of your house using any medium you would like—colored pencils, pastels, or watercolors. (If you did this last year, try picking a different location.)

1. Go to Google Earth and type in the address of your house or school.
2. You may want to begin with a pencil drawing. Try to see the picture as a series of geometric and curvilinear spaces.
3. Add in the colors with your medium of choice.

∞ Link: Google Earth

∞ Link: Example of a Pastel Drawing of a Ranch

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

New Hampshire and Virginia (pick one state)

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.9-10 p.65-72

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.41, 79

1. Draw an outline of New Hampshire and Virginia on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?
2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.
3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

WEEK 6 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 11

Solomon Carvalho: Westward from St. Louis

Materials: Westward with Fremont, geography notebook, United States Atlas

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

• DEFINITIONS

elevation: height above sea level

range: chain of mountains

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

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Term 1

→ LOCATE

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.114

1. Locate the Rio Grande River on p.114. It is the 3rd-longest river in the continental U.S., running about 1,900 miles from Colorado to the Gulf of Mexico.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Westward with Fremont Ch.9-10 p.58-71 "Solomon Carvalho citizen" - "of their guards."

→ MAP WORK

□ Map Resource: geography notebook

On your map, use a color pen or pencil to draw in the Republican River, the Arkansas River, the Rocky Mountains, and the Rio Grande River. Draw a dot at the bottom of Pikes Peak (one of the high mountain peaks of the Rockies) just north of the start of the Rio Grande River, label it New Year's Day 1854. Join the labels on the map and/or the recollection of places you have read about, so that you can begin to visually track the expedition's journey with a line.

WEEK 6 □ 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 12 *Southeastern U.S.*

□ Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank maps, geography notebook

PREP: You will need a blank map for today.

∞ Map Link: Blank Map of the Southeastern Region

→ MAP WORK

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.54-57

1. Use the United States map taped in your notebook. This week, you will begin to add southeastern states to the U.S. map in your notebook.

2. Read p.56-57.

3. On p.55, locate the following states: Kentucky, Arkansas, West Virginia, and Virginia. Add these to your United States map in your notebook.

4. Add these states and their capitals to the state capitals page.

5. Spend some time studying the states, their capitals, and the region. Next week, you will fill these in from memory in a blank Southeastern Region map.

6. Tape this map into your notebook and label it Southeastern Region.

∞ Map Link: Blank Map of Southeastern U.S.

→ MAP QUESTIONS

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.10-13

1. Describe the climate in the Southeast. [A: The Southeast is part of the Humid subtropical climate zone. This climate type is characterized by hot and humid summers and cool to mild winters.]

2. Turn to p.12-13. What are the natural disasters found in the Southeast? [A: tornado, drought, flooding, hurricane]

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

New York and North Carolina (pick one state)

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.11-12 p.73-80

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.45, 73

1. Draw an outline of New York and North Carolina on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?

2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Video Link: New River Gorge National Park

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

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Term 1

3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

WEEK 7 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 13

Solomon Carvalho: Hardships of the Trail

Materials: Westward with Fremont, geography notebook, United States Atlas

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.128

1. Locate the Colorado River on p.128. Starting in the Colorado mountains, the river runs 1,450 miles south, ending in the Gulf of California.

2. Locate the Gulf of California in the link. It is not located in the United States but is bordered by Mexico.

∞ Image Link: Gulf of California

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Westward with Fremont Ch.11 p.75-82 "It was four" - "permission to come."

→ MAP WORK

Map Resource: geography notebook

On your map, use a color pen or pencil to draw the Colorado River.

• DEFINITIONS

current: a body of water or air moving in a definite direction, especially through a surrounding body of water or air in which there is less movement

glacier: a large, persistent body of dense ice, snow, rock, sediment, and often liquid water that originates on land and moves continuously down slope under the influence of its own weight and gravity

avalanche: a rapid, sudden, and violent downslope movement of a large mass of snow, ice, rock, soil, and other debris

WEEK 7 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 14

Southeastern U.S.

Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook

PREP: You will need a blank map for today.

∞ Map Link: Blank Map of Southeastern U.S.

→ MAP WORK

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.55

1. Using a fresh blank map of the Southeastern U.S., fill out the states, capitals, and other labels you remember from last week.

2. Use the map in your notebook to check your work. Add anything you missed.

3. On p.55, locate the following states: Tennessee, Alabama, North Carolina, and South Carolina. Add these to the U.S. and Southeastern U.S. map in your notebook.

4. Add the states and capitals on the state capitals page.

5. Spend some time studying the states, their capitals, and the region.

Next week, you will fill in these new states and capitals from memory on a fresh Southeastern U.S. map.

→ MAP QUESTIONS

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.14-15

1. Look at p.14-15. When it is 9:00 am in California, what time is it in North Carolina? [A: 12:00 pm] There is a 3-hour difference between the western coast and the eastern region of the United States. The time zone in most of the Southeast is noted as Eastern time (GMT-4).

2. View the Westward Expansion map on p.15. In what years were most southeastern states added to the United States? [A: mostly 1783, but also 1810-1821 and 1842]

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Rhode Island and Vermont (pick one state)

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.13-14 p.81-87

📄 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.49, 51

1. Draw an outline of Rhode Island and Vermont on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?
2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.
3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

WEEK 8 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 15

Solomon Carvalho: Hardships of the Trail

📄 Materials: Westward with Fremont, geography notebook, United States Atlas

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

📄 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.128

1. Locate the Green River on p.128. What larger river is it a tributary of? [A: the Colorado River] The Green River is the main waterway in Utah.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Westward with Fremont Ch.12 p.83-89 “The company had” - “bed without speaking.”

→ WRITE

On a new page in your notebook, make a journal entry. Imagine you are on the expedition. Describe your journey and the importance of the rivers along the trek.

★ TEACHER TIP

Preview the content on p.87-89 where starvation and death are discussed and described. Summarize or skip sentences as needed.

• DEFINITIONS

tributary: a river or stream flowing into a larger river or lake

WEEK 8 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 16

Southeastern U.S.

📄 Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook

PREP: You will need a blank map for today.

∞ Map Link: Blank Map of Southeastern U.S.

→ MAP WORK

📄 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.55

1. Using a fresh blank map of the Southeastern U.S., fill out the states, capitals, and other labels you remember from last week.
2. Use the map in your notebook to check your work. Add anything you missed.
3. On p.55, locate the following states: Louisiana, Mississippi, Florida, and Georgia. Add these to the U.S. and to the Southeastern Region map in your notebook.
4. Add the states and capitals on the state capitals page.
5. Spend some time studying the states, their capitals, and the region. Next week, you will fill these in from memory on a new blank Southeastern U.S. map.

→ MAP QUESTIONS

📄 Map Resource: People on the Move (U.S. Atlas 6th Edition p.18-19 PDF)
∞ Link: U.S. Atlas 6th Edition PDF

1. The main map on this page is about the largest minority populations; it does not show European Caucasians, as they are the majority, and it

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Video Link: OCALA National Forest

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

represents the largest minority population by county.

2. What are the largest minority populations in the eastern U.S.? [A: Black or African American and two or more races, not Hispanic or Latino]
3. What minority is prevalent in Florida? [A: Hispanic or Latino]
4. What minority is prevalent in the southeast? [A: Black or African American]
5. In the eastern U.S., where do you see sections where American Indians/Alaskan Natives live? [A: North Dakota, South Dakota, Nebraska, Iowa, Minnesota, North Carolina]
6. In the eastern U.S., where do you see small sections where Asians live? [A: Wisconsin, Indiana, Pennsylvania, Massachusetts, New Jersey]

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Kentucky and Tennessee (pick one state)

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.15-16 p.89-95

☐ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.67, 77

1. Draw an outline of Kentucky and Tennessee on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?
2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.
3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

WEEK 9 ☐ 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 17

Solomon Carvalho: Hardships of the Trail

☐ Materials: Westward with Fremont, geography notebook, United States Atlas

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

☐ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.135

1. Locate the Sierra Nevada Mountains on p.135. In what state is the mountain range found? [A: California] View the video to learn more about the geology of the mountain range.
- ∞ Video Link: Sierra Nevada Mountains Geology

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Westward with Fremont Ch.13-14 p.90-103 "We are lost," - "family very soon."

→ MAP WORK

☐ Map Resource: geography notebook

In your notebook, draw the Sierra Nevada mountain range along the edge of California in your map. Add the Green River to your map.

WEEK 9 ☐ 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 18

Southeastern U.S. Regional map

☐ Materials: United States Atlas, blank maps, geography notebook

PREP: Make sure you have a blank map for today.

∞ Map Link: Blank Map of Southeastern U.S.

→ MAP WORK

☐ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.54-55

1. Using a fresh blank Southeastern U.S. map, fill out the states, capitals,

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

and other labels you remember from last week.

2. Use the map in your notebook to check your work. Add anything you missed.
3. On the topographical/physical map (p.54), is there anything you notice about the geographical physical features of the southeastern region? What geographical features stand out?
4. Locate the Appalachian Mountains. Remember that the mountain range starts in Canada, goes through the northeastern U.S., and ends in the southeastern region of North Carolina.
5. On your Southeastern Region map in your notebook, you will add the following geographical physical features from numbers 6 and 7.
6. Now find: Coastal Plain, Gulf of Mexico (recently renamed Gulf of America), Cumberland Plateau, and Cape Canaveral. Label this on your map.
7. Locate the Mississippi River. Label this on your map.
8. Spend some time studying the features you have added.

→ READ & DISCUSS

📖 Map Resource: Mississippi River map

Spend time today reading about the Missouri River from the American Rivers Website, as well as all the interesting captions.

∞ Link: Mississippi River

∞ Map Link: Mississippi River Map

→ MAP QUESTIONS

Answer the following questions from the Links above.

1. Where does the Mississippi River begin? [A: Lake Itasca, Minnesota]
2. Where is the mouth of the river? [A: Gulf of Mexico]
3. What rivers feed into the Mississippi River? [A: Missouri, Des Moines, Illinois]
4. Name some cities located on the river. [A: St. Paul, Minneapolis, St. Louis, Memphis, Baton Rouge]
5. What city is in the delta of the Mississippi River? [A: New Orleans]
6. Name some landmarks along the river.
7. What states does the river flow through? [A: You may need to use another atlas as well.]

WEEK 10 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 19

Solomon Carvalho: Hardships of the Trail

📖 Materials: Westward with Fremont, geography notebook, United States Atlas

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

📖 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.149

1. Locate the Wasatch Mountain Range on p.149. It runs about 160 miles from the Utah–Idaho border south to central Utah. It is the western edge of the greater Rocky Mountains and the eastern edge of the Great Basin region. Mount Nebo is the highest peak in the Wasatch Mountains.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Westward with Fremont Ch.15 p.104-111 “Put not your” - “of a genius.”

→ MAP WORK

📖 Map Resource: geography notebook

In your notebook, add the Wasatch Mountains to your map. Place a marker and label it “Feb. 1854 Climb.” While the chapter does not give us

• DEFINITIONS

precipice: a very steep rock face or cliff, especially a tall one

summit: the highest point of a hill or mountain

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

the name of the peak the group climbed, here is a video of two hikers climbing Mt. Nebo in the Wasatch Mountain Range.
∞ Video Link: Mt. Nebo

WEEK 10 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 20

Clay model of state; Southeastern Region

📋 Materials: United States Atlas, geography notebook, Model Magic clay (or you can make your own salt dough), cardboard or surface for model, paint, toothpicks or pins

PREP: Print the following blank map for today.

∞ Map Link: Blank Map of Southeastern U.S.

→ MAP WORK

📋 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.54-55

1. Using a fresh blank southeastern map, fill in the geographical features and states you remember.

2. Use the map in your notebook to check your work. Add anything you missed.

→ MAP WORK

You will spend today's lesson making a model of a state studied this term.

You may want to print out a blank map to use as a guide. You can paint your model, put in pins with flags to mark certain areas, or add other creative features. We have included an example for inspiration.

∞ Image Link: Clay Model Map of Idaho

WEEK 11 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 21

Catch-Up Day

→ CATCH UP

Use this time to catch up on lessons or notebook entries for geography, particularly if you had to skip some of your state journal pages.

WEEK 11 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 22

Catch-Up Day

→ CATCH UP

Use this time to finish your clay model, catch up on lessons in this or another course, or explore Extra Helpings.

WEEK 12 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 23

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

Answer question(s) related to the course.

Questions will come from:

Westward with Fremont

WEEK 12 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 24

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

Answer question(s) related to the course.

Questions will come from:

∞ Link: Northeastern U.S. Map

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 2

WEEK 1 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 25

Solomon Carvalho: Hardships of the Trail

Materials: Westward with Fremont, geography notebook, United States Atlas

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.149

1. Locate the capital of Utah. What is it? [A: Salt Lake City]
2. Locate Parowan. It was officially settled in 1851 by a Mormon party led by George Smith. The word parowan is a Native American word meaning "evil water."

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Westward with Fremont Ch.16-17 p.112-121 "The kind Heap" - "with his family."

→ MAP WORK

Map Resource: geography notebook

In your notebook, mark the city of Parowan and Salt Lake City. You may put a large dot in the area and label it "Carvalho's Rest & Recovery 1854." Draw a dotted line from Parowan to Salt Lake City. This is where Carvalho's journey separates from Fremont's expedition.

• DEFINITIONS

basin: land surrounded by higher ground

arid: very dry

valley: low land between hills

• IMPORTANT DATES

Utah Territory was established in 1850.

WEEK 1 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 26

Midwest U.S.

Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook

PREP: Print 3 copies of the U.S. blank map. You will use these in the next several lessons.

∞ Map Link: Blank Map of the U.S.

→ INTRO

You will continue to add to your United States map this term and read the interesting stories about how our states got their crazy shapes. You will also continue with the regional maps and filling in topographical/physical information.

→ MAP WORK

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.84-87

1. This term will cover the states in the midwestern and southwestern regions of the United States.
 2. Read p.86-87.
 3. Now you will add the following states from the Midwest to the U.S. map in your notebook: Indiana, Ohio, Illinois, and Michigan.
 4. Add the states and capitals on the state capitals page in your notebook.
 5. Add in the postal abbreviations for the states on the state capitals page in your notebook. You can use the link provided.
 6. Spend some time studying the states, their capitals, and the region. Next week, you will fill these in from memory.
- ∞ Link: State Abbreviations

→ MAP QUESTIONS

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.84-85

1. Which states touch Lake Superior? [A: Minnesota, Wisconsin, Michigan]
2. Which states touch Lake Michigan? [A: Michigan, Wisconsin, Illinois,

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Link: Grand Teton National Park

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 2

Indiana]

3. Which states touch Lake Huron? [A: Michigan]

4. Which states in the Midwest touch Lake Erie? [A: Michigan, Ohio, Pennsylvania]

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Ohio and Louisiana

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.17-18 p.97-103 (pick one state)

☐ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.107, 69

1. Draw an outline of Ohio and Louisiana on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?

2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.

3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

WEEK 2 ☐ 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 27

Solomon Carvalho: Hardships of the Trail

☐ Materials: Westward with Fremont, geography notebook, United States Atlas, map link

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

☐ Map Resource: map link, United States Atlas p.135

1. Locate the Sevier River in the link map. Can you follow it south to find the Virgin River? What state do they share in common? [A: Utah]

2. Locate San Bernardino, the Mojave Desert, and the San Bernardino Mountains (national forest) on p.135. What state are these located in? [A: California]

∞ Map Link: Utah Map

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Westward with Fremont Ch.18-19 p.122-134 “Egloffstein and Carvalho” - “of Los Angeles.”

→ MAP WORK

☐ Map Resource: geography notebook

In your notebook:

1. Draw the Sevier River and Virgin River in the Utah area.

2. Move to the southern California region and draw the Mojave Desert, San Bernardino, and the San Bernardino Mountains.

3. Make a dotted line showing Carvalho’s route to California from Utah.

• DEFINITIONS

calumet: a long-stemmed, heavily ornamented tobacco pipe used by Indigenous North American peoples on ceremonial occasions (sometimes called a peace pipe)

retinue: a group of followers, servants, assistants, or advisors that accompany an important person

terrain: the physical features and surface of a specific area of land

bluff: a steep, broad, rounded cliff or headland, often found bordering a river, beach, or coastal area

WEEK 2 ☐ 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 28

Midwest U.S.

☐ Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank U.S. map, geography notebook

PREP: Make sure you have a blank map of the U.S.

∞ Map Link: Blank Map of U.S.

→ MAP WORK

☐ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.85

1. Using a fresh blank map, fill out the states, capitals, and other labels you remember from last week.

2. Use the map to check your work. Add anything you missed.

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 2

3. On p.85, locate the following states: Iowa, Missouri, Wisconsin, and Minnesota. Add these to your blank map.
 4. Add the states and capitals to the state capitals page in your notebook.
 5. Add in the postal abbreviations for the states on the state capitals page in your notebook. You can use the link provided.
 6. Spend some time studying the states, their capitals, and the region. Next week, you will fill these in from memory.
- ∞ Link: State Abbreviations

→ MAP QUESTIONS

□ Map Resource: Student United States Atlas p.10-11

1. Describe the climate in the Midwest. [A: Most of the Midwest is part of the Continental Climate Zone. That means these areas have four distinct seasons, with cold and snowy winters and warm to hot summers.]
2. Turn to p.12-13. What are the natural disasters found in the Midwest? [A: blizzard, flood, tornado]

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Indiana and Mississippi

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.19-20 p.105-112 (pick one state)

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.91, 71

1. Draw an outline of Indiana and Mississippi on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?
2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.
3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

WEEK 3 □ 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 29

Solomon Carvalho: After the Adventure

□ Materials: Westward with Fremont, geography notebook

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.135

1. Locate Los Angeles on p.135. This is the largest city in the state of California. It has an estimated 3.8 million people living there (24-25 census).
2. Locate San Francisco on p.135. The city gained fame and numbers shortly after the California Gold Rush in 1848-1849. While Carvalho's journey took him to Los Angeles, Fremont's expedition ended in San Francisco.
3. What ocean borders California? [A: Pacific Ocean]

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Westward with Fremont Ch.20-21 p.135-147 "Joseph Newmark," - "work together."

→ MAP WORK

□ Map Resource: geography notebook

In your notebook, label the California cities of Los Angeles and San Francisco. Place a big "X" in Los Angeles and label it "Carvalho's Journey Ends."

• DEFINITIONS

zanjero: an official in charge of water distribution from irrigation canals

• IMPORTANT DATES

California became an official state in 1850 after the Gold Rush of 1848-1849.

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

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Term 2

WEEK 3 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 30

Midwest U.S.

Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook

PREP: Make sure you have a blank map of the U.S.
∞ Map Link: Blank Map of U.S.

→ MAP WORK

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.85

1. Using a fresh blank map, fill out the states, capitals, and other labels you remember from last week.
2. Use the map in your notebook to check your work. Add anything you missed.
3. On p.85, locate the following states: Kansas, Nebraska, South Dakota, and North Dakota. Add these to your blank map.
4. Add the states and capitals to the state capitals page in your notebook.
5. Add in the postal abbreviations for the states on the state capitals page in your notebook. You can use the link provided.
6. Spend some time studying the states, their capitals, and the region. Next week, you will fill these in from memory.

∞ Link: State Abbreviations

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Illinois and Alabama (pick one state)
Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.21-22 p.113-119

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.89, 59

1. Draw an outline of Illinois and Alabama on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?
2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.
3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Video Link: Black Hills National Forest

WEEK 4 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 31

Solomon Carvalho: After the Adventure

Materials: Westward with Fremont, geography notebook

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.8-9

Spend today looking at the Physical Map of the United States on p.8-9. What are some observations you can make about the areas Carvalho traveled? Pay attention to the “Cross Section” image at the bottom of the page. How much of that was traveled by the group?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Westward with Fremont Ch.22-23 p.148-155 “It was August,” - “can’t take orders.”

→ MAP WORK

Map Resource: geography notebook

In your notebook, take a look at your map. You have been following and connecting lines showing Carvalho’s journey. Remember, Colonel Fremont continued on the expedition as planned while Carvalho recovered in

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

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Term 2

Utah. Take a look at the map in the link. Add a solid line that denotes the expedition's trail that Fremont continued after leaving Utah. If time permits, use it to add or enhance your map. How well did you create your map and follow the route to the Pacific Ocean? Does it stay close to the 38th parallel line you first drew?
∞ Map Link: Carvalho Journey Map

WEEK 4 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 32 *Midwest U.S.*

□ Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook

PREP: Print out the blank map linked.
∞ Map Link: Midwest Region blank map

→ MAP WORK

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.84-85

1. Using a fresh blank Midwest U.S. map, fill out the states, capitals, and features you remember.
2. Use the U.S. map in your notebook to check your work. Add anything you missed.
3. You will use your newly printed blank map of the Midwest region to add geographical/topographical physical features.
4. On the topographical/physical map (p.84), is there anything you notice about the physical features in the Midwest region? What geographical features stand out?
5. Locate Lake Erie, Lake Huron, Lake Michigan, and Lake Superior. Label the new map.
6. Locate the Central Lowlands and Great Plains. Label the new map.
7. Locate the Mississippi River and the Missouri River. Label your new map.
8. Tape this map into your notebook on the correct page designated for the regional maps and label it as Midwest Region
9. Spend some time studying the features you have added.

→ MAP QUESTIONS

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.8-9

1. Read p.8
2. Are the Midwest states east or west of the Appalachian Mountains? [A: west] What is the biggest mountain range west of the Midwest region? [A: Rocky Mountains]
3. Based on the cross-section model, what can you guess about the elevation in most of the Midwest?
4. What is the predominant natural vegetation in the Midwest?

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Maine and Missouri (pick one state)

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.23-24, p.121-126

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.35, 101

1. Draw an outline of Maine and Missouri on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?
2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.
3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

★ TEACHER NOTE

You will need various colors of construction paper for a project next week. (Lesson 34)

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 2

WEEK 5 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 33

Solomon Carvalho: After the Adventure

Materials: Westward with Fremont, geography notebook

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Westward with Fremont Ch.23-24 p.155-164 "Fremont refused to" - "from his community."

→ WRITE

In your notebook, using the last two pages of your "Solomon Carvalho's Journey" section, add a book introduction. You are introducing Carvalho's manuscript/book to a generation not familiar with the hardships of frontier westward exploration. What do you think the audience should know about Carvalho and his experience?

WEEK 5 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 34

Midwest U.S.

Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook

PREP: Print out the blank map linked.

∞ Map Link: Midwest Region blank map

→ MAP WORK

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.84-85

1. Using a fresh blank Midwest map, fill in the geographical features and states you remember.
2. Use the map in your notebook to check your work. Add anything you missed.
3. This completes your Midwest U.S. map.

→ MAP QUESTIONS

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.84-85

1. The Midwest is known for being lowland, plains, and plateaus. However, the states to the west start seeing big mountain peaks.
2. Can you find the tallest mountain in the Midwest? [A: Black Elk Peak 7,244 ft/2,207m in South Dakota] It is found in the Black Hills area.
3. Find the largest lake in the Midwest. Lake Superior is the largest freshwater lake in the world (based on surface area). It is part of the Great Lakes of America (Lake Superior, Lake Huron, Lake Erie, Lake Michigan, and Lake Ontario).
4. What Midwest states share a border with Canada? [A: North Dakota, Minnesota, Ohio, and Michigan]

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Arkansas and Michigan (pick one state)

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.25-26 p.127-134

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.61, 97

1. Draw an outline of Arkansas and Michigan on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?
2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.
3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

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Term 2

WEEK 6 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 35

Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, geography notebook

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Florida and Texas (pick one state)

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.27-28 p.135-142

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.63, 125

1. Draw an outline of Florida and Texas on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?
2. Read the pages in the book and atlas for each state. This week, there is also a video on Florida that you may watch. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.
3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading and short video. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

∞ Video Link: Florida

WEEK 6 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 36

Local map

Materials: local map, geography notebook

PREP: This lesson requires that you take a look at a local map of your area. There are some city or town websites that might have online versions of maps for you to view. However, if it is not easily found, Google Maps is an alternative source to use.

→ MAP QUESTIONS

Map Resource: Local Map (suggest you use Google Maps)

1. Locate your street. (A parent will probably need to help.) Do you live within the city limits? Mark your street on the map.
2. Do you have a downtown or city center? If so, in what direction would you travel from your home to get there? Locate your local seat of government—city hall, town hall, or municipal building. Do you live north, south, east, or west of it?
3. How are the streets laid out in your city? Is any portion of your city laid out in a grid? (Older areas may utilize the grid. Newer sections may utilize cul-de-sacs. Other patterns like loop roads and diagonals may be used.) If so, what direction do the streets run? (north-south, east-west, etc.)
4. What are the streets named in this area? Do you see any “streets,” “avenues,” or “lanes”? What other street types (e.g., way, court, parkway) can you find? Is there a pattern for when these names are used (such as cul-de-sacs being “courts”)?
5. Locate your local police department, fire station, and hospital. How would you travel there from your home? Do you have more than one police station, fire station, or hospital? If so, mark where they are all located. Are they close to each other or far apart? What do you notice about how they are spaced?
6. Look for familiar places (grocery stores you go to, places of worship, friends' homes, etc.). How would you travel there from your home? Choose one of the familiar places you found and find at least 2 different routes to travel there from your home. Which one do you think is faster? Mark the familiar places on your map.
7. Locate any parks or outdoor areas in your city. Mark them on your map. What direction would you travel to get there? Are there any within walking distance from your home?

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 2

WEEK 7 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 37

Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, geography notebook

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Iowa and Wisconsin (pick one state)

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.29-30 p.143-149

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.93, 111

1. Draw an outline of Iowa and Wisconsin on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?

2. Read the pages in the book and atlas for each state. This week, there is also a video on Iowa that you may watch. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.

3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading and short video. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

∞ Video Link: Iowa

WEEK 7 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 38

Southwest U.S.

Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook

→ MAP WORK

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.115

1. Now you will add states from the Southwest to the U.S. map that is in your notebook: Oklahoma, Texas, New Mexico, and Arizona.

2. Add the states and capitals on the state capitals page in your notebook.

3. Add in the postal abbreviations for the states on the state capitals page in your notebook. You can use the link provided.

4. Spend some time studying the states, their capitals, and the region.

Next week, you will fill these in from memory.

∞ Link: State Abbreviations

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

California and Minnesota (pick one state)

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.31-32 p.150-158

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.135, 99

1. Draw an outline of California and Minnesota on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?

2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.

3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

WEEK 8 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 39

Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, geography notebook

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Oregon and Kansas (pick one state)

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.33-34 p.159-165

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.147, 95

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 2

1. Draw an outline of Oregon and Kansas on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?
 2. Read the pages in the book and atlas for each state. This week, there is also a video on Kansas that you may watch. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.
 3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading and short video. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.
- ∞ Video Link: Kansas

WEEK 8 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 40

Southwest U.S. region

☐ Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook

PREP: Make sure you have a blank map of the U.S. and print out the blank Southwest Region blank map.

∞ Map Link: Blank Map of U.S.

∞ Map Link: Southwest Region blank map

→ MAP WORK

☐ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.115

1. Using a fresh U.S. blank map, fill out the states, capitals, and features you remember.
2. Use the map in your notebook to check your work. Add anything you missed.
3. Now use your newly printed Southwest Region blank map to add geographical/topographical physical features.
4. On the topographical/physical map (p.114), is there anything you notice about the physical features in the southwest region? What features stand out?
5. Locate and label your blank map: Coast Plain, Llano Estacado (Staked Plain), Colorado Plateau, and Edwards Plateau.
6. Locate the Gulf of California and the Gulf of Mexico (Gulf of America). Label the new map.
7. Locate the Rio Grande. Label your new map.
8. Tape this map into your notebook on the correct page designated for the regional maps and label it as Southwest Region.
9. Spend some time studying the features you have added.

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

West Virginia and Nevada (pick one state)

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.35-36 p.167-173

☐ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.81, 145

1. Draw an outline of West Virginia and Nevada on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?
2. Read the pages in the book for each state.
3. Add at least 3 comments to your maps.

WEEK 9 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 41

☐ Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, geography notebook

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Nebraska and Colorado (pick one state)

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.37-38 p.175-181

☐ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.103, 137

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 2

1. Draw an outline of Nebraska and Colorado on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?
 2. Read the pages in the book and atlas for each state. This week, there is also a video on Colorado that you may watch. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.
 3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading and short video. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.
- ∞ Video Link: Colorado

WEEK 9 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 42

Southwest U.S. region

📖 Materials: United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook

PREP: Print out the blank map linked.

∞ Map Link: Southwest Region blank map

→ MAP WORK

📖 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.114-115

1. Using a fresh blank Southwest map, fill in the geographical features and states you remember.
2. Use the map in your notebook to check your work. Add anything you missed.
3. This completes your Southwest U.S. map.

→ READ & DISCUSS

📖 Map Resource: Rio Grande from the American Rivers Website

Spend time today reading about the river as well as all the interesting information. Note: Rio means river, and Grande means big in Spanish.

∞ Link: Rio Grande

∞ Map Link: Rio Grande map

→ MAP QUESTIONS

Answer the following questions from the Links above.

1. Where does the Rio Grande begin? [A: Rocky Mountains]
2. Where is the mouth of the river? [A: Gulf of Mexico/Gulf of America]
3. What rivers feed into the Rio Grande in the United States? [A: Pecos, Devils, Chama, and Puerco]
4. Name some cities located on the river. [A: El Paso, Las Cruces, Albuquerque, Ciudad Juárez, Nuevo Laredo]
5. What city is in the delta of the Rio Grande? [A: Brownsville]
6. Name some landmarks along the river.
7. What states does the river flow through? You may need to use another atlas as well.

WEEK 10 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 43

📖 Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, geography notebook

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

North Dakota and South Dakota (pick one state)

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.39-40 p.183-187

📖 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.105, 109

1. Draw an outline of North Dakota and South Dakota on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?
2. Read the pages in the book and the atlas for each state. This week,

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 2

there is also a video on both Dakota states to watch. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.
3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading and short video. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.
∞ Video Link: The Dakotas

WEEK 10 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 44

Torn Paper State Project

Materials: United States Atlas, geography notebook, construction paper (various colors), glue stick, pen/marker

→ MAP WORK

Torn paper state project

1. This week, you will make a map of the state you chose to feature from previous lessons. (You may use one from Term 1 or Term 2.)
2. Using only torn pieces of paper (DO NOT use scissors), tear the construction paper into smaller pieces of paper to create the shape of the state, and use a different color piece of paper to tear other landmark pieces you want to include (mountains, lakes, rivers).
3. Then, in your notebook, arrange the pieces the way you want. With a glue stick, paste the pieces together as best you can.
4. Label the state and the other pieces you added.
5. View the link to an example of a small town torn paper project.

∞ Image Link: Example Torn Paper Project

WEEK 11 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 45

Catch-Up Day

→ CATCH UP

Use this time to catch up on lessons in this or another course, or explore Extra Helpings.

WEEK 11 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 46

Catch-Up Day

→ CATCH UP

Use this time to catch up on lessons in this or another course, or explore Extra Helpings.

WEEK 12 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 47

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

Answer question(s) related to the course.

Questions will come from:
Westward with Fremont

WEEK 12 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 48

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

Answer question(s) related to the course.

Questions will come from:
∞ Link: Midwest Region Map

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 3

WEEK 1 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 49

John Audubon: Beloved Boy

Materials: This Strange Wilderness, United States Atlas, World Atlas (optional), notebook, blank 1850s U.S. map, scissors, tape or glue

PREP: In your notebook, you should set aside the last 5 pages for this term's day 1 assignments. Label the section "Audubon's Wilderness Travels." You will also need a blank 1850s United States map to mark the places mentioned in your readings.
∞ Map Link: 1850s U.S. Map

→ INTRODUCTION

1. In this term, we will follow the life of the naturalist John James Audubon as he explores the wilderness of America during the late 1800s, a time when the new frontier still had much to learn about the land's wildlife.
2. You may want to review vocabulary as needed.

→ LOCATE

Map Resources: United States Atlas p.27, World Atlas or world map link
∞ Map Link: World Map

1. On the world map link or in the Student World Atlas (p.30-31), can you locate Haiti and France? The island of Haiti has two main languages: Haitian Creole and French. Due to its history of French colonization, the island still speaks and uses French in formal settings. The majority of people, however, speak Haitian Creole (French-influenced).
2. Now look at p.27 in your United States Atlas. Locate Pennsylvania. All these places were significant to John James Audubon. He was born in Haiti, raised in France, and then came to Pennsylvania when he was a young man.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

This Strange Wilderness Prologue-Ch.1 p.xv-7 "In the heat" - "a great wilderness."

→ MAP WORK

Map Resources: notebook, 1850s U.S. map
Print the 1850s map. Cut along the border of the page. Tape or paste this page on your first blank page in the "Audubon's Wilderness Travels" section. You will be tracking the places he visits. Label this map, "Audubon's Travels."

• DEFINITIONS

observation: careful watching to collect information

naturalist: someone who studies plants and animals in nature

medium: the material used by an artist (e.g., watercolor)

field notes: short written records made during observation

WEEK 1 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 50

West U.S.

Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook

PREP: Print 5 copies of the U.S. blank map.
∞ Map Link: Blank Map of the U.S.

→ INTRO

You will continue to add to your U.S. map this term and read the stories about how our states got their crazy shapes.

→ MAP WORK

- Map Resource: United States Atlas p.128-131, U.S. map in notebook
1. This term will cover the states in the western U.S., including Alaska and Hawaii.
 2. Now you will add states from the west to the map that is already in your notebook: Montana, Wyoming, and Colorado.

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 3

3. Add the states and capitals on the state capitals page in your notebook.
 4. Add in the postal abbreviations for the states on the state capitals page in your notebook. You can use the link provided.
 5. Spend some time studying the states, their capitals, and the region. Next week, you will fill these in from memory.
- ∞ Link: State Abbreviations

→ READ

📄 Map Resource: Colorado River from the American Rivers website
Spend time today reading about the river as well as all the interesting information.

∞ Link: Colorado River

∞ Map Link: Colorado River map

→ MAP QUESTIONS

Answer the following questions from the Links above.

1. Where does the Colorado River begin? [A: Rocky Mountains]
2. Where is the mouth of the river? [A: Gulf of California]
3. What rivers feed into the Colorado River? [A: Green, Gunnison, San Juan, Little Colorado, Dirt Devil, Escalante, Kanab, Parla]
4. Name some cities located on the river. [A: Phoenix, Las Vegas, Great Junction, Yuma, Moab, Bullhead City, Glen Springs]
5. What city is in the delta of the Colorado River? [A: Mexicali]

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Montana and Washington (pick one state)
Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.41-42 p.189-196

📄 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.143, 151

1. Draw an outline of Montana and Washington on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?
2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.
3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

WEEK 2 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 51

John Audubon: America My Country

📄 Materials: This Strange Wilderness, United States Atlas, notebook, markers, colored pencils

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

📄 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.47
Locate Philadelphia. How would you describe its location?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

This Strange Wilderness Ch.2 p.9-16 “Audubon sat in” - “on the frontier.”

→ VIEW

1. This is an engraving of a flatboat from the 1800s, similar to what Audubon would have traveled down the Ohio River in.
- ∞ Image Link: Flatboat of 1800s
2. Look at either the painting of the Eastern Phoebe on p.8 or the Wild Turkey on p.14. Similar to picture study, describe what you see—colors, textures, background, foreground, etc.

• DEFINITIONS

émigré/immigrant: a person who moves from one country to another

plantation: a large farm where crops are grown and, previously, enslaved labor was used

apprentice: a learner who trains under an expert

• EXTRA HELPING

You may want to watch part of this video to learn more about the painting of Wild Turkey.

∞ Video Link: Audubon's Wild Turkey (ends at 4:12)

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 3

→ MAP WORK

📄 Map Resource: 1850s U.S. map in notebook
Using colored markers to outline the borders, outline the state of Pennsylvania on your map. Write Pennsylvania inside the borders. Use a light shade of colored pencil to shade in the state.

WEEK 2 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 52 *Western U.S.*

📄 Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook

→ MAP WORK

📄 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.129, blank map of the U.S.
1. Using a fresh blank map, fill out the states, capitals, and other labels you remember from last week.
2. Use the map to check your work. Add anything you missed.
3. On p.129, locate the following states: Idaho, Nevada, and Utah. Add these to your map in your notebook.
4. Add the states and capitals to the state capitals page in your notebook.
5. Add in the postal abbreviations for the states on the state capitals page in your notebook. You can use the link provided.
6. Spend some time studying the states, their capitals, and the region. Next week, you will fill these in from memory.
∞ Link: State Abbreviations

→ MAP QUESTIONS

📄 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.10-13
1. Describe the climate in the West. (The Southwest is part of the Temperate West--parts of Texas and Oklahoma.)
2. Describe the Arid Steppe (parts of Texas, Arizona, and New Mexico) climate zones.
3. Turn to p.12-13. What are the natural disasters found in the West?

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Idaho and Wyoming (pick one state)
Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.43-44 p.197-202
📄 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.141, 153
1. Draw an outline of Idaho and Wyoming on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?
2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.
3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Video Link: Zion National Park

WEEK 3 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 53 *John Audubon: The American Woodsmen*

📄 Materials: This Strange Wilderness, United States Atlas, notebook, markers, colored pencils

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

📄 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.66-67
1. Locate the state capital city of Kentucky. What is it? [A: Frankfort]
2. Along the Indiana border, can you locate the city of Henderson? You will find the John James Audubon State Park in Henderson, Kentucky.

• DEFINITIONS

citizenship: legal belonging to a country

commerce: buying and selling goods (Audubon also worked in business.)

natural history: the study of animals, plants, and the environment

• EXTRA HELPING

In this 5-minute video, you can learn more about the painting of

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 3

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

This Strange Wilderness Ch.3 p.17-27 "Owning a store" - "had never existed."

→ VIEW

Watch the video for a short tour of John James Audubon State Park in Henderson, Kentucky.

∞ Video Link: John James Audubon State Park

→MAP WORK

□ Map Resource: 1850s U.S. map in notebook

Using colored markers to outline the borders, outline the state of Kentucky on your map. Write Kentucky inside the borders. Use a different light shade of colored pencils to shade in the state.

The Trumpeter Swan and why the version in the book is not the finished one.

∞ Video Link: Audubon's Trumpeter Swan (Watch 8:18-14:34)

WEEK 3

30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 54

Western U.S.; Local Map

□ Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Video Link: Redwood National Park

→ MAP WORK

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.129

1. Using a fresh blank map, fill out the states, capitals, and other labels you remember from last week.
 2. Use the map to check your work. Add anything you missed.
 3. On p.129, locate the following states: Washington, Oregon, and California. Add these to your map in your notebook.
 4. Add the states and capitals to the state capitals page in your notebook.
 5. Add in the postal abbreviations for the states on the state capitals page in your notebook. You can use the link provided.
 6. Spend some time studying the states, their capitals, and the region. Next week, you will fill these in from memory.
- ∞ Map Link: State Abbreviations

→ MAP QUESTIONS

□ Map Resource: Local Map

1. Can you find any bodies of water or watercourses? (oceans, lakes, reservoirs, ponds, wetlands, rivers, streams, creeks, and so forth) How many bodies of water are there in your city?
2. Using the scale, estimate the distance of the closest water feature to your house. How far is it? Could you walk there? Drive there? How long would it take?
3. If your map shows physical features, can you tell which direction the rivers, streams, or creeks run? Do they all flow in the same direction? Can you see smaller tributaries that flow into larger ones?
4. What is the largest body of water in your city?

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Utah and Oklahoma (pick one state)

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.45-46 p.203-209

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.149, 123

1. Draw an outline of Utah and Oklahoma on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?
2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.
3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

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Term 3

WEEK 4 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 55

John Audubon: Down the Mississippi

Materials: This Strange Wilderness, map link, notebook

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

Map Resource: Map Link

Map Link: Mississippi River Map

Locate the Mississippi River. It is the second-longest river in the United States, flowing about 2,350 miles. Observe the map link. Do you recognize the rivers from Term 1 and Term 2? Which ones?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

This Strange Wilderness Ch.4 p.29-36 "When Audubon reached" - "met Mrs. Pirrie."

→ VIEW

Pick one of the illustrations in the chapter to observe and describe what you see—colors, textures, background, foreground, etc.

→ MAP WORK

Map Resource: 1850s U.S. map in notebook

Draw the Mississippi River on the map located in your notebook. Feel free to attempt to recreate a bird picture in your notebook.

• DEFINITIONS

riverine: related to rivers

navigation: moving along waterways

delta: where a river meets the sea and deposits sediment

migration: seasonal movement of animals (especially birds)

WEEK 4 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 56

Western U.S. region

Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook

PREP: Print out the blank map linked.

Map Link: Western Region blank map

→ MAP WORK

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.128-129, blank map of the U.S.

1. Using a fresh U.S. blank map, fill out the states, capitals, and features you remember.

2. Use the map in your notebook to check your work. Add anything you missed.

3. Now, use your newly printed blank map of the western region to add geographical/topographical physical features.

4. What is the landform name for the "tips" of land along a coastline that jut into the sea/ocean? [A: cape or point]

5. Starting at the northern end of the west coast, follow the coastline and locate any capes or points. [A: Cape Flattery, Cape Disappointment, Cape Blanco, Cape Mendocino, Point Reyes, Point Conception] Add them to your blank map.

6. In Washington, what body of water is just north of Cape Flattery? [A: Strait of Juan de Fuca] This body of water connects to another body of water. What is it? [A: Puget Sound] A sound is a small body of water that usually connects to a larger sea or ocean.

7. The area of land between the Pacific Ocean, the Strait of Juan de Fuca, and Puget Sound creates a peninsula known as the Olympic Peninsula. Add these (strait, sound, and peninsula) to your map.

8. Tape this map into your notebook on the correct page designated for the regional maps and label it as Western Region.

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

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Term 3

New Mexico and Arizona (pick one state)

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.47-48 p.211-218

☐ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.121, 119

1. Draw an outline of New Mexico and Arizona on separate pages.

Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?

2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.

3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

WEEK 5 ☐ 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 57

John Audubon: On The Wing

☐ Materials: This Strange Wilderness, United States Atlas, notebook, markers, colored pencils

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

☐ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.68-69

Locate New Orleans on the map. Notice how the Mississippi runs through this area and will continue about 100 miles downstream to empty at the Gulf of Mexico.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

This Strange Wilderness Ch.5 p.39-48 “Lucretia Pirrie was” - “for Liverpool, England.”

→ VIEW

Pick one of the illustrations in the chapter to observe and describe what you see—colors, textures, background, foreground, etc.

→ MAP WORK

☐ Map Resource: 1850s U.S. map in notebook

Using colored markers to outline the borders, outline the state of Louisiana on your map. Write Louisiana inside the borders. Use a different light shade of colored pencils to shade in the state. Feel free to attempt to recreate a bird picture.

• DEFINITIONS

plumage: a bird’s feathers

wingbeat: the movement of a bird’s wings while flying

anatomy: the structure of an organism

field sketch: a quick drawing made outdoors to record movement or shape

WEEK 5 ☐ 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 58

Western U.S. region

☐ Materials: Our States Have Crazy Shapes, United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook

PREP: Print out the blank map linked.

∞ Map Link: Western Region blank map

→ MAP WORK

☐ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.128

1. Using a fresh blank western region map, fill in the geographical features and states you remember.

2. Use the map in your notebook to check your work. Add anything you missed.

3. This week, find the Rocky Mountains (the Rockies). Label your US map. It is the largest range in North America (3,000 mi/4,800 km). Find the tallest peak along the Rockies in Colorado: [A: Mount Elbert at 14,437 ft./4,400m]

4. Find and label the Great Basin, Mojave Desert, and the Columbia



Term 3

Plateau.

→ MAP QUESTIONS

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.10, 128

1. Find the Great Basin on p.128. What states are part of the Great Basin?

[A: Nevada, half of Utah, and sections of Idaho, Wyoming, Oregon, and California] It is mostly defined by its hydrographic nature (the way the water flows). All the rain in the area evaporates into the ground or flows into lakes. The water does not find its way into bigger water outlets like the Gulf of Mexico (Gulf of America) or an Ocean.

2. If the water doesn't flow into the bigger outlet waters, where do you think the water ends up? [A: It drains into smaller basins/lakes such as the Great Salt Lake, Pyramid Lake, and the Humboldt Sink.]

3. What kind of ecosystem do you think the Great Basin sustains? [A: Desert]

4. Look at p.10. What is the climate like in that area? [A: Arid Steppe, Desert, Dry Summer]

→ READ & NOTEBOOK

Alaska and Hawaii (pick one state)

Our States Have Crazy Shapes Ch.49-50 p.219-225

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.133, 139

1. Draw an outline of Alaska and Hawaii on separate pages. Observe the boundaries, and try to answer the following questions: What geographical features make up the boundaries of the state? Is there anything unique about the borders?

2. Read the pages in the book for each state. You may want to read about each state at a time and work on the map for that state.

3. Add any comments to your maps that you learned about in the reading. Aim to include at least 3 interesting things about the state and its boundaries.

4. You have completed your individual states notebook. If time permits, watch this short video on how the country has changed in the last 200 years.

∞ Video Link: How the US Map Has Changed

WEEK 6 □ 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 59

John Audubon: Birds of America

□ Materials: This Strange Wilderness, Student World Atlas, notebook

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

□ Map Resource: Student World Atlas p.82-83

1. Locate London on p.83. Which countries are part of the United Kingdom? [A: England, Scotland, Wales, and Northern Ireland]

2. Locate France on p.83. Looking at p. 82—which body of water separates the UK from France? [A: The English Channel, or as it is called in France, “la Manche.”]

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

This Strange Wilderness Ch.6 p.49-60 “Two months at” - “home a star.”

→ VIEW

If time permits, watch the following video:

∞ Video Link: Engraving of Audubon Prints

• DEFINITIONS

folio: a very large book format (used for Audubon's plates)

subscriber: someone who pays in advance to receive installments of a publication

engraving: a method of printing images from metal plates

portfolio: a collected set of works

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 3

WEEK 6 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 60

Western U.S. region; Scale Outdoor Map

Materials: United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook, paper or poster board (large enough for your outdoor space to be represented as 1 inch=10 feet), paper, scissors, ruler, tape measure, pencil, and tape or glue

PREP: Print the blank map linked.

∞ Map Link: Western Region blank map

PREP: Choose an outdoor space to draw a scale map of. The space could be a portion of a playground, garden, etc. It needs to have objects in it (play structure, benches, pond, etc.) that can be measured and added to the map. Don't make the space so big that it cannot be measured fairly easily with a tape measure.

→ MAP WORK

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.114-115

1. Using a fresh blank western region map, fill in the geographical features and states you remember.
2. Use the map in your notebook to check your work. Add anything you missed.
3. This completes your Western U.S. map.

→ MAP WORK (SCALE MAP OF OUTDOOR SPACE)

1. Today, we will begin work on a scale map of an outdoor space.
2. Using a tape measure, measure the length and width of your outdoor space. Write it down in your geography notebook.
3. Next, measure the main features in the space and make a list of them with their measurements. (things like benches, tables, pavilions, play equipment, etc.)
4. Keep your list in the geography notebook, and next week, we will convert it to a smaller scale.

WEEK 7 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 61

John Audubon: Team Audubon

Materials: This Strange Wilderness, United States Atlas, notebook, markers, colored pencils

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.27

Locate New Jersey, New York, Pennsylvania, Maine, and Washington, D.C. on the map. These are all located in the northeastern region of the United States. The "great pine forest" mentioned in today's reading is believed to be in the northeastern part of Pennsylvania.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

This Strange Wilderness Ch.7 p.61-66 "Audubon did not" - "what happened next."

→ VIEW

Pick one of the illustrations in the chapter to observe and describe what you see—colors, textures, background, foreground, etc.

→ MAP WORK

Map Resource: 1850s U.S. map in notebook

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 3

On the map in your notebook, use a different color marker to outline each state and different light colors to shade inside. Write the name of each state inside its boundaries: New Jersey, New York, and Maine.

WEEK 7 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 62

Alaska and Hawaii; Scale Outdoor Map

Materials: United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook, paper or poster board (large enough for your outdoor space to be represented as 1 inch=10 feet), paper, scissors, ruler, tape measure, pencil, and tape or glue

→ MAP WORK

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.128-131, U.S. map in notebook

1. Add the states Alaska and Hawaii.
 2. Notice that these are not part of the continental United States.
 3. Add the states and capitals on the state capitals page in your notebook.
 4. Add in the postal abbreviations for the states on the state capitals page in your notebook. You can use the link provided.
 5. Spend some time studying the states, their capitals, and the region. Next week, you will fill these in from memory.
- ∞ Map Link: State abbreviations

→ MAP QUESTIONS

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.10, 132

1. Read p.132. Alaska is the largest U.S. state.
2. What are the borders of Alaska? [A: Canada, the Arctic Ocean, the Pacific Ocean, the Bering Sea, and the Chukchi Sea]
3. Find the Bering Strait. What country is to the west of Alaska? [A: Russia]
4. What is the predominant climate in Alaska? (p.10) [A: mostly Cold Wet and Polar Tundra]

→ MAP WORK (SCALE MAP OF OUTDOOR SPACE)

1. Get your measurements from your geography notebook and determine if the scale of 1 inch=10 feet will work for your map. (If it will not fit on your paper or poster board, you will need to adjust the scale.)
2. Draw the outline of your determined space onto the paper/poster, making sure to note the scale on a map key.
3. Using your dimensions from last week, make notes in your journal about what size they will be drawn using the scale you determined.
4. Draw the features onto blank paper, which will be cut out next week. (This will make it easier to place them in the correct positions later.)

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Video Link: Hawaii Volcanoes National Park

WEEK 8 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 63

John Audubon: Team Audubon

Materials: This Strange Wilderness, United States Atlas, notebook, markers, colored pencils

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

Map Resource: United States Atlas p.55

Locate Kentucky, South Carolina, Alabama, and Florida on your map. These states are located in the southeast region of the United States.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

This Strange Wilderness Ch.7 p.68-72 "I was surprised" - "is the Idea."

→ VIEW

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 3

Pick one of the illustrations in the chapter to observe and describe what you see—colors, textures, background, foreground, etc.

→ MAP WORK

□ Map Resource: 1850s U.S. map in notebook

On the map in your notebook, use a different color marker to outline each state and different light colors to shade inside. Write the name of each state inside its boundaries: Kentucky (if you haven't already), South Carolina, Alabama, and Florida.

WEEK 8 □ 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 64

United States Map, Scale Outdoor Map

□ Materials: United States Atlas, blank map, geography notebook, paper or poster board (large enough for your outdoor space to be represented as 1 inch=10 feet), paper, scissors, ruler, tape measure, pencil, and tape or glue

→ MAP WORK

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.128, blank map

1. Using a fresh blank U.S. map, fill in as many of the 50 states you remember.
2. Use the back of your map and list as many states and capitals as you remember.
3. Use the map in your notebook to check your work. Add anything you missed.
4. This completes your United States map.

→ MAP QUESTIONS

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.12-13, 138-139

1. Read p.138-139.
2. How many islands make up the state of Hawaii? [A: archipelago of 8 major islands] What are the 8 major islands that make up the state of Hawaii? [A: Hawai'i, Maui, Koho'olawe, Moloka'i, Lana'i, O'ahu, Kaua'i and Ni'i'hau]
3. What ocean surrounds the islands of Hawaii? [A: Pacific Ocean]
4. Look at p.12-13. What are the natural hazards in the state of Hawaii? [A: volcanic activity, tsunamis, hurricane, and earthquake]

→ MAP WORK (SCALE MAP OF OUTDOOR SPACE)

1. Get your drawings from last week and cut out the features.
2. Carefully place the features in the correct spots on your map. This is the most difficult part, as you may need to go back to your outdoor spot and measure from the "sides" of your space and in between features, to get the most accurate map.
3. Glue or tape down the features. You now have a scale map of an outdoor space. If you use tape, you could even come up with your own redesign of the space.

The student will see the difficulty and hopefully appreciate even more how map-making is such a precise job through the mapping activity. Don't let it stress them out; they will have to guesstimate to an extent.

WEEK 9 □ 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 65

John Audubon: This Strange Wilderness

□ Materials: This Strange Wilderness, United States Atlas, notebook, markers, colored pencils

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas p.84-85

Explore the map of the Midwest region of the United States. Locate the Mississippi River, the Missouri River, and the Platte River. Now take a look at the states that today make up the Great Plains area (North Dakota,

★ TEACHER NOTE

Note the words to end today's reading. A couple paragraphs after today's reading are skipped due to a description of a violent act.

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 3

South Dakota, Nebraska, and Kansas). During Audubon's exploration, this area was still only a territory and not divided into states.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

This Strange Wilderness Ch.8 p.74-80 "From its earliest" - "only another day."

→ VIEW

Pick one of the illustrations in the chapter to observe and describe what you see—colors, textures, background, foreground, etc.

→ MAP WORK

📄 Map Resource: 1850s U.S. map in notebook

Use a different color to highlight and shade the Great Plains area on the map in your notebook.

WEEK 9 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 66

United States Territories

📄 Materials: United States Atlas

→ INTRO

You just covered and mapped the 50 states of the United States of America. The U.S. also has 14 territories and commonwealths around the globe. This week, you will explore more about them.

→ MAP QUESTIONS

📄 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.154-157

1. Read the section in your United States Atlas about U.S. Territories.
2. What are the five largest U.S. territories? [A: Puerto Rico, U.S. Virgin Islands, American Samoa, Northern Mariana Islands, and Guam]
3. What countries and waters surround Puerto Rico and the U.S. Virgin Islands? [A: They are both in the Caribbean Sea with the Atlantic Ocean to the north and east and Haiti and the Dominican Republic to the west.]
4. Which one has a bigger population, Puerto Rico or the U.S. Virgin Islands? [A: Puerto Rico with 3.2 million]
5. Now, which territories are located in the Pacific Ocean region? [A: American Samoa, Northern Mariana Islands, and Guam]
6. What sea is to the West of Guam and the Northern Mariana Islands? [A: Philippine Sea]
7. What are the capitals of the five largest territories? [A: San Juan, Puerto Rico; Charlotte Amalie, U.S. Virgin Islands; Pago Pago, American Samoa; Capitol Hill, Northern Mariana Islands; and Hagåtña (Agana), Guam]

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Video Link: US Territories Explained

WEEK 10 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 67

John Audubon: The Strange Wilderness, Then and Now

📄 Materials: This Strange Wilderness, United States Atlas, notebook, markers, colored pencils

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ LOCATE

📄 Map Resource: United States Atlas p.15, 115

1. Locate Texas on the map. What states border Texas? [A: Louisiana, Arkansas, Oklahoma, New Mexico]
2. Locate Missouri on the map. What states border Missouri? [A: Arkansas, Oklahoma, Kansas, Nebraska, Iowa, Illinois, Kentucky, and Tennessee]

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

• DEFINITIONS

legacy: something left behind for future generations

conservationist: a person working to protect nature

ethics: principles about right and wrong (introduce briefly: collecting vs. modern non-lethal study)

citizen science: community volunteers contributing to scientific data (e.g., bird counts)

★ TEACHER NOTE

Note the words to begin today's

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 3

This Strange Wilderness Ch.8-9 p.80-91 “On June 12th” - “nature around me.”

→ MAP WORK

📄 Map Resource: 1850s U.S. map in notebook
Using colored markers to outline the borders, outline the states of Texas and Missouri on your map. Write their names inside the borders. Use a different light shade of colored pencils to shade in each state. How colorful is your map? Are you impressed with all the places Audubon traveled to?

→ WRITE

On the last page in your Audubon section, write a letter to Audubon reflecting on how you feel about his contribution to ornithology and geography.

reading. A couple paragraphs prior to today's reading are skipped due to a description of a violent act.

WEEK 10 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 68

Clay model of state

📄 Materials: United States Atlas, geography notebook, Model Magic clay (or you can make your own salt dough), cardboard or surface for model, paint, toothpicks or pins

→ MAP WORK

You will spend today's lesson making a model of a state studied this term. You may want to print out a blank map to use as a guide. You can paint your model, put in pins with flags to mark certain areas, or add other creative features. We have included an example for inspiration.
∞ Image Link: Clay Model Map of Idaho

WEEK 11 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 69

Catch-Up Day

→ CATCH UP

Use this time to catch up on lessons in this or another course, or explore Extra Helpings.

WEEK 11 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 70

Catch-Up Day

→ CATCH UP

Use this time to catch up on lessons in this or another course, or explore Extra Helpings.

WEEK 12 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 71

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

Answer question(s) related to the course.

Questions will come from:
This Strange Wilderness

WEEK 12 📅 30m Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.) - Lesson 72

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

Answer question(s) related to the course.

Questions will come from:
∞ Link: United States Map

Geography: Grade 8 (U.S.)

Examination

Term 1

- Westward with Fremont: Describe one of Solomon Carvalho's expedition encounters with a geographical landmark, such as a river or mountain range. Be sure to name the landmark and its regional area.
- Fill in the blank map of the Northeastern States with their capital cities:
Link: [Northeastern US Map](#)

Term 2

- Westward with Fremont: Tell about the importance of expeditions, such as Fremont and Carvalho's journey to California, for the study of geography.
- Fill in the blank map of the Midwest States with their capital cities:
Link: [Midwest Region Map](#)

Term 3

- This Strange Wilderness: Describe how Audubon's passion for birds was influential in exploring the American Wilderness. Be sure to use a specific example of a location he experienced.
- Fill in the blank map of the United States:
Link: [United States Map](#)